

Unconscious Bias and Scorer Objectivity

The Society for Science is intent on creating a fair and just judging process for all students at Regeneron ISEF. “Reward the best and encourage the rest,” is the unofficial motto of the grand award judging process. We ask that anyone scheduled to judge at Regeneron ISEF this coming May, take a moment to review the information below about bias.

Awareness of potential biases that we each may bring to the experience will help in providing a more equitable and objective judging process. Our goal as judges is to determine the suitability of all finalists for an award. We look for good science or engineering. We should not allow any extraneous factors to color our judgment. As judges, we are also working to encourage our students to pursue their dreams in science and engineering. We can only do that when we respect all finalists.

Judges should be aware of and attempt to overcome the potential influence of any bias on their scoring, so that they can score each project as objectively as possible. For example, we encourage judges to recognize their differences in expectations for project sophistication and writing style between grade levels. Bias can affect one’s entire scoring pattern or may occur only in specific instances. We have provided more information on this topic below and ask that you consider your own potential biases as you review projects.

There are many resources available; one such resource that we quote below is, the University of California, San Francisco Office of Diversity and Outreach website:

<https://diversity.ucsf.edu/resources/unconscious-bias>:

“**Bias** is a prejudice in favor of or against one thing, person, or group compared with another usually in a way that’s considered to be unfair. Biases may be held by an individual, group, or institution and can have negative or positive consequences. There are two types of biases:

1. **Conscious bias** (also known as **explicit** bias) and
2. **Unconscious bias** (also known as **implicit** bias)

It is important to note that biases, conscious or unconscious, are not limited to ethnicity and race. Though racial bias and discrimination are well documented, biases may exist toward any social group. One’s age, gender, gender identity, physical abilities, religion, sexual orientation, weight, and many other characteristics are subject to bias.”

At Regeneron ISEF, the goal is to recognize our biases, to put them aside, and to judge the finalists to determine their suitability for an award, looking for good science or engineering. Judging is intended to be an educational experience that is conducted as ethically and fairly as possible.